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The British Conquest of Burma

ANGLO-BURMESE RELATIONS AND THE KONBAUNG DYNASTY

British contact with the Burmese dates back to 1619 when two envoys from the British East India Company, Henry Forest and John Staveley, visited the court of Anaukhpetlun (r. ca. 1605–1628) to recover the estate of Thomas Samuel, the company's resident merchant in Chieng Mai. The East India Company would later establish commercial contacts with Burma when Thalun (r. ca. 1629–1648) granted the company permission to set up a factory at Syriam. The factory at Syriam remained in operation from 1647 until 1657. The British would continue to maintain a presence in Burma until 1740 and the outbreak of the Pegu rebellion.

The next contact between the Burmese and the British occurred in July 1756 when Alaùngpayà conquered Dagon (now Rangoon) from the Mon and discovered the presence of three British ships in the harbor. Realizing the significance of European armaments, Alaùngpayà attempted to seize the ships but was rebuffed by the English captain. Alaùngpayà's diplomatic gaffe would color later dealings with the East India Company as Anglo-Burmese relations would go from crisis to crisis.

Eager to establish relations with Alaùngpayà following his victory over the Mon, the East India Company dispatched Ensign Robert Lester as Ambassador Extraordinary to Burma in 1757, bearing a treaty of friendship and alliance between Burma and the East India Company, along with gifts of guns and gunpowder. The Treaty of Friendship and Alliance was signed on July 27, 1757, and granted the East India Company the island of Negrais and land at Bassein for factories. In return, the East India Company promised one cannon and several hundred pounds of gunpowder annually.